

Chapter 8: The Problem With Being Watched Back

She didn't go to work.

Not because she didn't have it yet.

But because after yesterday, even the idea of “normal life” felt like it was waiting for her to behave correctly again.

Mia didn't comment on it.

Which was worse.

Mia always had something to say.

Even if it was insulting.

Even if it was unnecessary.

Silence didn't fit her.

Mia was in the kitchen.

Standing still.

Looking at nothing in particular.

That was new too.

“You're quiet,” she said cautiously.

Mia blinked once.

“I'm thinking.”

"That sounds dangerous."

Mia smiled faintly. "It usually is."

She made tea just to do something with her hands.

The kettle filled the silence too well.

Too loudly.

She couldn't stop thinking about yesterday.

The interview.

The system.

The word recommended.

And Mia sitting there like she had always been part of paperwork reality had signed without her permission.

"Mia," she said.

"Yes?"

"Do you remember when you first met me?"

Mia didn't answer immediately.

That pause again.

That pause was becoming a language of its own.

Then Mia said:

"I've always known you."

"That's not what I asked."

Mia turned slightly.

"I answered what matters."

She frowned.

"That's not how memory works."

Mia smiled.

"You're learning it does."

A notification popped up on her phone.

She didn't recognize the sender.

No name.

Just a message:

"You've been seen."

She froze.

"Did you send this?" she asked immediately.

Mia looked at her phone.

"No."

Too fast again.

She held the phone tighter.

"What does that mean?"

Mia leaned back against the counter.

"It means someone is paying attention."

"To what?"

Mia looked at her.

"To the parts of you that are not usually observed."

That sentence made her uncomfortable in a way she couldn't explain.

Like being described too accurately by someone who shouldn't have access to the data.

She opened her photo gallery again.

Scrolled.

Same patterns.

Same café images.

Same missing presence.

But then—

she stopped.

A new photo.

One she didn't remember taking.

Her sitting at the table.

Smiling.

But the camera flash reflection in the window—

showed something else.

A faint outline.

Beside her.

Not clear.

Not solid.

But there.

Her breath caught.

“Mia…” she whispered.

Mia was suddenly behind her shoulder.

“Don’t zoom in,” Mia said softly.

She froze.

“Why?”

Mia didn’t answer immediately.

Instead, she said:

“Because clarity is not always your friend.”

She turned sharply.

“This is not normal.”

Mia nodded.

“No.”

“That’s it? That’s your response?”

Mia shrugged.

“You wanted honesty.”

“I wanted explanation.”

Mia smiled slightly.

“You rarely get both.”

That night, she tried something different.

She spoke out loud.

Not to Mia.

But to the room.

“If you’re not real,” she said carefully, “then why do other people react like you are?”

Silence.

Then—

Mia answered anyway.

“I didn’t say I’m not real.”

She turned.

Mia was sitting on her bed.

Calm.

Present.

Too present.

"You've been avoiding that question," she said.

Mia tilted her head.

"Because you're not asking the right one."

Her stomach tightened.

"Then what is the right question?"

Mia smiled.

Soft.

Almost sad.

"Why do you need the world to agree with what keeps you alive?"

That didn't feel like comfort anymore.

It felt like structure.

Like something carefully built over time.

She stepped closer.

"I don't understand you."

Mia nodded.

"You're not supposed to yet."

"That's not fair."

Mia stood up slowly.

And for the first time—

she looked slightly further away than usual.

Like she wasn't fully anchored in the room.

Like she could step out of it if she wanted to.

Or if she had to.

"You're changing," Mia said quietly.

"I'm not doing anything."

"That's the problem."

Silence.

She swallowed.

"Am I in danger?"

Mia looked at her for a long moment.

Then smiled again.

But this time it was small.

Careful.

Almost protective.

"No," Mia said.

Then added:

"Not in the way you think."

And that answer—

somehow—

did not help at all.

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